



Self-loading rifle

The British-made L1A1 self-loading rifle was the standard rifle of the Australian Army from 1960 to 1992. The term self-loading referred to its repeat-fire action. Gas-operated, it ejected spent cartridges and loaded new ones automatically.

Waves of attacks

D Company advanced toward Long Tan, 3 miles (5 km) from Nui Dat. They were unaware that there was an enemy regiment massed in a rubber plantation near the village. At 3:40 p.m., a platoon from D Company clashed with forward troops of the Viet Cong and forced them to withdraw. Returning in greater numbers half an hour later, the Viet Cong launched waves of attacks, hoping to encircle and destroy the Australians.

The situation looked bleak for the Australians. D Company was spread out, leaving some elements isolated. Monsoon rains decreased visibility, preventing the American jets called in to provide support from launching an airstrike. The beleaguered company relied on artillery batteries at Nui Dat, which bombarded within 50 yards of their position and fired nearly nonstop, even though their position was twice struck by lightning. To make the situation worse, a relief force was not immediately dispatched due to concern about leaving Nui Dat undefended. Reinforcements in the form of 10 armored personnel carriers and some 100 men eventually left at 6 p.m.

“Being **mortared** ... want **all artillery possible** ... Enemy left flank. **Could be serious.**”

RADIO MESSAGES FROM D COMPANY, AT 4:26 AND 4:31 P.M., AUGUST 18, 1966